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Senegal: New fighting threatens return of remaining IDPs

Despite the scarcity of information on the numbers, it is estimated that during 2005 more than 65 percent of the people displaced from their homes in the southern region of Casamance were able to return. This followed the signing in December 2004 of a peace agreement between the Senegalese government and the rebel group Mouvement des Forces Démocratiques de Casamance (MFDC) to end a conflict that started in 1982. However, increasing insecurity along the region's northwest border with the Gambia may have prevented some 12,400 other internally displaced people (IDPs) from going home. Armed clashes which moved from the Casamance border with Guinea-Bissau to the south, to the Bignona area in the northwest on the border with Gambia between a hardline faction of the MFDC and other factions favouring negotiations, is threatening the future of the peace process. Fighting between MFDC rebels and Senegalese army units sent in mid-August 2006 to secure the zone close to the border in the Sindian district, where rebels have set up a base, led to the displacement of between 2,000 and 10,000 residents to neighbouring villages, while between 3,500 and 5,500 people moved across the border into the Gambia.

In other areas, where IDPs have returned spontaneously without any assistance, various obstacles have continued to hamper their sustainable reintegration such as the limited social infrastructures and services, and the presence of mines that impede them from resuming farming. The government and the MFDC held a number of rounds of talks on the practical modalities of the December 2004 agreement. Some post-conflict reconstruction programmes are in the process of being implemented, including mine-clearance operations. The full recovery of IDPs and the consolidation of a sustainable peace in the Casamance will depend on the determination of the government and the MFDC – including its hardline wing – to abide by their commitments.

Background and causes of displacement

The separatist movement has been alive in Casamance province since before Senegal's independence from France in 1960. However, the first large demonstration for provincial independence did not occur until late 1982 when the MFDC organised a march on the provincial capital, Ziguinchor. At the root of the protests has been the complaint by the MFDC that the Wolofs, Senegal's dominant ethnic group, had economically and politically marginalised the Diola, the ethnic majority group in Casamance. The southern province is almost separated from the rest of Senegal by the Gambia. Violent demonstrations continued throughout the 1980s until the MFDC officially declared its armed struggle for Casamance independence in 1990. At this time, it initiated its first organised attacks on military and civilian targets in the region (Manley, November 1998). From then on, rebel incursions and government counter-measures have established a cycle of sporadic violence that has continued to plague the southern province. The region became increasingly unsafe and isolated from the rest of the country.

Civilians have fled their homes as a result of both rebel incursions and mopping-up operations by the Senegalese army. In mid-May 2001, another round of violence broke out in the region. The Senegalese army and MFDC forces engaged in heavy fighting, particularly in the *département* of Bignona. The army shelled parts of the province and burned houses in pursuit of rebel forces. This intensification of fighting came only two

months after a peace agreement was signed between the newly-elected President Abdoulaye Wade of Senegal and MFDC leader Augustin Diamacoune Senghor, calling for *inter alia* the return of refugees and IDPs. The peace agreement was the third of its kind since the early 1990s.

Renewed fighting broke out between May and June 2002 when a government military offensive uprooted between 10,000 and 20,000 people – with about half fleeing to the Gambia and the other half becoming internally displaced (IRIN-WA, 10 May 2002; USCR, 2003). Further fighting was reported in July 2002, and again in January 2003.

In 2003, intermittent rebel attacks and Senegalese military reprisals caused the internal displacement of an estimated 17,000 people, mostly from Ziguinchor, the largest town in Casamance, in Bignona, and the Oussouye area near the border with Guinea-Bissau. Many of the displaced took refuge with relatives and quickly returned home during lulls in fighting (USCR, May 2004). During 2004, the level of violence fell off sharply, and although sporadic clashes between the Senegalese army and the MFDC were reported, some people started returning home (IRIN, 22 November 2004). As a result of political unrest in Casamance, inhabitants of the region have found themselves subject to harassment and human rights abuses by both sides to the conflict (AI, 17 February 1998).

The death of the leader of the hardline wing of the MFDC, Sidi Badji, in May 2003 raised hopes for a peaceful settlement to the conflict. Badji, who was

83, had consistently held out against any compromise with the government in Dakar. His death paved the way for further negotiations between the Senegalese government and the MFDC's veteran president, Augustin Diamacoune Senghor, a Roman Catholic priest, known for his softer stance. Indeed, on 30 December 2004, the Senegalese government and the Casamance rebel group signed a peace accord to end the conflict. The accord provides for the parties "once and for all to give up armed struggle and the use of violence" (AFP, 30 December 2004).

The accord was followed by detailed talks on issues such as disarmament and the reintegration of ex-combatants. The two series of negotiations on the practical modalities of the agreement which have taken place in Foundiougne, about 160 km southeast of Dakar, appear to have improved prospects for lasting peace in Casamance (OCHA, 22 June 2005; Correspondence with UNDP, 7 February 2006). However, various obstacles have continued to prevent a second round of negotiations (Foundiougne II) taking place. In March 2006, clashes between Salif Sadio, a hardline wing of the MFDC, and other MFDC factions which favour negotiations with the government, spilled over into Guinea-Bissau where the Sadio faction had established positions (IRIN, 20 March 2006; Xinhua News Agency, 29 March 2006; IRIN, 14 April 2006). Once flushed out by the Guinea-Bissau army, the rebels moved to the Sindian district close to the border with the Gambia where they set up a base. This prompted the deployment of the Senegalese army whose offensive against the MFDC faction led to the displacement of between 2,000 and

10,000 residents to neighbouring villages and of between 3,500 and 5,500 people into the Gambia since mid-August 2006 (UNOCHA, 6 Sept. 2006; IRIN, 15 Sept. 2006; Correspondence with WFP, 19 Sept. 2006).

Scarce figures

Reports on the number of people displaced by conflict in Casamance have always been scarce. Most of the displaced appear to stay with relatives, thus making it difficult to identify them. In addition, the temporary nature of the displacement further complicated the compilation of reliable statistics (IRIN, 6 March 2003; Correspondence with WFP, 19 Sept. 2006). The overall number of displaced varies according to the source. According to a study done in 2003, there were in total 64,000 internally displaced persons in Senegal; 47,000 were in the district of Ziguinchor and 17,000 in the district of Kolda (WFP, 27 August 2004, p.5). Other sources cite the number of 50,000 people who had fled their homes since the conflict broke out in 1982 (IRIN, 3 January 2006). With both the peace agreement signed on 30 December 2004 and the continuous improvement of the security situation throughout, it was estimated that more than 65 per cent of the people displaced had returned and as of December 2005 a further 12,400 were still expected to return (Correspondence with UNDP, 7 February 2006; IRIN, 24 March 2006, 15 June 2006). However, it is estimated that since mid-August, between 2,000 and 10,000 people have been newly displaced as a result of fighting between the Senegalese army and the MFDC. The displaced who moved to the southern part of the Bignona district come from villages

located in the northern Casamance at the border with Gambia (Correspondence with WFP, 19 Sept. 2006).

Obstacles to IDP return and reintegration

Although there has been no profound assessment of the return process, which is spontaneous and without any assistance, the majority of the returnees are facing obstacles to their full reintegration (Correspondence with UNDP, 25 January 2006). There are projects aiming at rebuilding houses and social infrastructure, but not yet enough to facilitate the reintegration of the returnees. The conflict has caused the abandonment and/or destruction of physical infrastructure, the collapse of the agriculture-based economy and the disintegration of social infrastructure such as health centres and schools. Civil insecurity due to the presence of rebel fighters in the northwest and increased poverty in the east of the region have reduced the ability of inhabitants to cope with natural, economic or social traumas (WFP, 27 August 2004, p.5; WB, 13 August 2004, p.9; IRIN, 24 March 2006). It is therefore urgent to accelerate the implementation of the provision of the agreement calling for aid and reconstruction for returnees in Casamance.

The threat posed by landmines is another obstacle to IDP return and reintegration. Roads and tracks around Ziguinchor as well as areas of Oussouye and Bignona have been riddled with mines during the course of the conflict (Manley, November 1998). Some 125 villages have been abandoned in Ziguinchor district because of landmines. Many IDPs are prevented from resuming their life in

their area of origin because they cannot access infested lands to restart agricultural activities safely (WFP, 27 August 2004, p.5). In a recent UNDP study covering some 251 villages of the Casamance, 93 villages were identified as being riddled with landmines and unexploded ordnance while 60 others were abandoned. The most affected districts were Niaguis, Nyassia and Diattacounda. Landmines claimed 689 victims, the majority in Ziguinchor and Sedhiou districts (Correspondence with UNDP, 25 August 2006).

Humanitarian response

In response to the fighting in Casamance, the government of Senegal provided prompt resettlement assistance to some of the families forced to flee their homes in the region. In June 2001, the government launched, with the support of donors and other humanitarian agencies, the Programme for Revival of Economic and Social Activities (PRAESC) in Casamance. The programme consists of de-mining, demobilisation, reconstruction and community development linked to reintegration, and longer-term sustainable development activities. The PRAESC is implemented in cooperation with the World Food Programme (WFP), United Nations Children's Fund and other implementing partners, as well as national and international non-governmental organisations.

Under the December 2004 peace agreement, the government promised to spend about \$402 million on the region's reconstruction and development (OCHA, 22 June 2005). Although the mine clearance process has not yet started, in the framework of a *Programme Intégré*

de Lutte Antimines en Casamance, the government is planning to study and identify all mine-affected areas, to continue to educate the population about the danger posed by mines, and to provide assistance to the victims of landmines and their families. Meanwhile in conformity with the provisions of the Ottawa Convention, the Senegalese government has adopted a law banning the use of antipersonnel mines. The United Nations Development Programme is assisting the government to complete mine clearance of the Casamance region by mid-2009 (Correspondence with UNDP, 18 January 2006).

Within the framework of its 2005-2006 Post-conflict Relief and Rehabilitation programme in the Casamance, the WFP carries out, among other activities, community-based programmes involving food-for-work and/or food-for-training, alphabetisation, agricultural assets and provides special support to highly vulnerable groups such as handicapped people and orphans. However, donor response to aid appeals has been poor. With only 35 per cent of the WFP's 2005-2006 \$18.6 million recovery programme for Casamance being met, WFP decided to extend the programme for an additional 12 months (WFP, 27 August 2004, 6 June 2006).

Since the beginning of its Casamance conflict resolution programme in 1999, USAID has been funding peace-building activities in the north of Casamance, such as those aimed at creating income-generating jobs for IDPs and rehabilitation of local infrastructure to help increase local capacity. USAID is also funding grassroots conflict resolution and mitigation activities that

seek to address the causes of conflict and increase popular support for peace (USAID, 14 June 2004).

At the local level, the human rights organisation *Rencontre Africaine pour la Défense des Droits de l'Homme*, funded by USAID, is providing humanitarian assistance as well as human rights advocacy for IDPs and refugees in Senegal. This includes rebuilding homes destroyed by the fighting in Casamance, and providing counselling and legal services.

By and large, sustainable and safe return and reintegration of IDPs will depend on the improvement of security and the progress made in the reconstruction and rehabilitation of public infrastructures.

Note: This is a summary of the IDMC's internal displacement profile. The full profile is available online [here](#).

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Note: All documents used in this overview are directly accessible on the [List of Sources](#) page of the Senegal country page.

About the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre

The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre, established in 1998 by the Norwegian Refugee Council, is the leading international body monitoring conflict-induced internal displacement worldwide.

Through its work, the Centre contributes to improving national and international capacities to protect and assist the millions of people around the globe who have been displaced within their own country as a result of conflicts or human rights violations.

At the request of the United Nations, the Geneva-based Centre runs an online database providing comprehensive information and analysis on internal displacement in some 50 countries.

Based on its monitoring and data collection activities, the Centre advocates for durable solutions to the plight of the internally displaced in line with international standards.

The Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre also carries out training activities to enhance the capacity of local actors to respond to the needs of internally displaced people.

In its work, the Centre cooperates with and provides support to local and national civil society initiatives.

For more information, visit the Internal Displacement Monitoring Centre website and the database at www.internal-displacement.org

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